

Western Education and the fate of Sociocultural Reproduction in Sub-Saharan Africa: A reflection on the Yorubas in Southwestern Nigeria. *

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Abstract

From post-colonisation to globalisation and economic transition in Sub-Saharan Africa and the African continent at large, the infusion and acceptance of Western education are having a huge impact on indigenous knowledge and the sociocultural ecosystem. It then becomes imperative to explore the intricacies of the modernisation wave on the preservation and sustainability of the sociocultural identity and uniqueness of these diverse groups. It is against this backdrop that this study seeks to build on existing empirical and theoretical analysis in the evaluation of Western education and the fate of sociocultural reproduction in sub-Saharan Africa. It will take a cue from conceptual evidence of the waning culture of Yoruba descent in the Southwestern part of Nigeria. The overarching objective of this study is to problematise the

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proliferation of Western culture over indigenous culture and then to provide a pragmatic approach to decolonising education, considering this has a strong influence on the order of things. The relevance of this study cannot be overemphasised, seeing the socioeconomic momentum, multicultural concentration, and the educational impulse in the southwestern corridor of the country. Hence, a step in the right direction will not only restore value for indigenous knowledge but also preserve rich history and heritage and, more importantly, the transference of this indigenous knowledge to surviving generations.

Keywords: sociocultural reproduction, indigenous knowledge, linguistic hegemony, sub-Saharan Africa

1 Introduction

One of the lingering products of colonial relations is schemed in the definition of “valid knowledge” and the deterministic hegemony of how such knowledge should be produced, processed, validated, and disseminated. This asymmetric relation also reflects a dominant claim to authenticity and power diffusion. Examining things critically, Scott (1995) in what he termed the spatialisation of colonial modernity, argued that the introduction of foreign knowledge, material cultures and practices is the bane of the changes observed in indigenous living. This colonial modernity was bequeathed and wrapped in an illusion of benevolence. That is, the infiltration of the western imperialism, mainly in education, politics, government, and what have you, is often contrived and justified under the cloak of magnanimity and rescue, or, of best-practices.

The growing expansion of this imperialism syndrome is adjudged in the ideological construct of the “white man’s burden”- a perceived notion and assumed responsibility of

the West in advancing the other part of the world (Domosh, 2006; Berger, 1966). Hence, the topical discourse on hegemony and decolonisation remain one of the most contested concepts as far as Africa is concerned. In the wake of the rapidly growing globalisation agenda, a sceptical memorandum litters the nooks and crannies of the continent of Africa, from Cairo to Cape Town, in a seeming appraisal of the past. Without doubt, the continent of Africa is still in a recovery state from colonial hangovers, with different countries still striving to attain stability.

Because of this, the concept of decolonisation reverberates in the development landscape of the continent. However, this poses a critical concern in terms of the possibility of absolute dissociation from Western influence. Obviously, the impact of the colonial decades and the complexities of interference on the culture and identity of the indigenous group still lingers with pockets of influence. And there continues to be a cry for realignment to cultural stock and historic antecedence, as well as an emerging campaign for indigenous knowledge inclusion in the body of knowledge. The recognition of the value and relevance of this indigenous and cultural knowledge is the awakening stimulus for the previously colonised continent (Dei, 2011).

Admittedly, the cultural knowledge of a particular group of people or a commonwealth is rooted in their social formation, history, culture, and demography, and forms the very essence of survival and the guide to their existence. Not only that, but cultural learning could also embellish healing and reconnection of body, mind and soul (Dei, 2011). Existing evidence suggest that cultures in Africa are well historicised outside the whims and caprices of colonisation. Within the ambit of these cultures, the rich historical knowledge and heritage confer identity and meaning to their existence.

In defining what indigenous knowledge means, Roberts (1998) conceptualised it as knowledge accumulated in time by a group of people who by several years of unbroken residence have an in-depth understanding of their space and have developed a mechanism of trans-

ference of this knowledge in the form of proverbs, stories, myths and so on, from one generation to another Kawano (2011, p 84). The challenge, however, is that this knowledge has been ostracised within the purview of modernity *pari passu* the hegemonic dominance of the so-called superior valid knowledge, which thus far has shaped and formed the experiences of the African descents.

Colonial epistemics continue to flourish, entrenched as formal education and have been challenged to create inequitable linkages along racial ladder, gender, language, ability, religion, class/status, and sexual orientation (Kempf, 2011). The baffling twist to this argument is the gradual homogenisation and mimicking of Western styles in culture, politics, economic practices and education by the so-called indigenous people. The quest to bridge racial inferiority complex and match-up intellectually is making the proliferation of Western ideologies seamless. The imprint of whiteness traverses all the sustaining pillars of the present society: politics, economics, culture and education (Kawano, 2011, p 83). Curiously, emerging social and cultural formation is fast reproducing in that order, which is a threat to the sustenance and perpetuation of indigenous knowledge and culture.

It is upon this background that this study seeks to build upon existing empirical and theoretical analysis of Western education and the fate of sociocultural reproduction in sub-Saharan Africa, taking a cue from conceptual evidence of the waning culture of the Yoruba descent in the Southwestern part of Nigeria. The overall objective of this study is to problematise the proliferation of Western culture over indigenous culture and then proffer a pragmatic approach to decolonising education.

2 The Case for Language in the Sociocultural Reproduction Discourse

Language remains the most significant element and vehicle of any culture, a marker of identity, a tool for self-realisation, a conduit through which expressions can be communicated and a medium through which knowledge is transferred (Thiong'o, 1986). In the African linguistic reality, the concept of mother tongue is tantamount to the cultural identity of any group of people. In a broader perspective, mother tongue is defined as the unique language of a culture, which forms the basis of interaction within that environment and is an essential language that nurtures a child before contact with any formal learning.

Just as language forms the underpinning of communication and interaction in a culture, the same way the role of language in laying the foundations of education cannot be overemphasised. According to Owu-Ewie and Eshun (2015), language cannot be separated from education because it is through it that knowledge is disseminated. To put this in proper perspective, Wolff (2005, p 3) rightly frames the language-education relationship in this context, "language is not everything in education, but without language, everything is nothing in education". This implies that education is structured upon a linguistic framework.

Hence, in the education discourse, the language of education has always been contentious, most especially in multicultural and multilingual societies when weighing its effect on the quality of education received. The proliferation and dominance of the English language in the formal education framework has, in previous decades, thrown seemingly insurmountable and unprecedented challenges to inclusiveness and the incorporation of indigenous knowledge. Many anti-colonial scholars (Dei and Kempf, 2006; Wane, 2006; Smith, 1999; Thiong'o, 1986) are confronted with the challenge of dismantling this stronghold in the

process of sorting the best mechanism for decolonising education.

In the African reality, the English language, as well as other languages adopted as the lingua franca rather than indigenous language, has gained wide acceptance and uncontested medium of communication due to the dynamic multicultural and multilingual characteristics of countries, particularly in the sub-Saharan Africa region. In fact, language and communication are critical elements in the learning process to such an extent that linguistic scholars (Olagbaju and Akinsowon, 2014; Osborn, 2007; A.O., 1998) have drawn a parallel between the use of indigenous languages in the learning process and their effectiveness in students' understanding, assimilation, and articulation. However, the opposite is obtainable and absorbed by many educational systems and countries in the region.

According to Ouane and Glanz (2010), Africa tops the list as the only continent where the majority of children start school using a foreign language. Heugh *et al.*, (2007) carried out an empirical study on compliance with the Ethiopian education policy on the use of mother tongue as the medium of instruction for the first eight years of schooling. Comparing the learning achievements of students in year 8, it was established that students who had their education in their mother tongue as the medium of instruction performed better in all subjects, including English. This is an indication that learning is effective when conducted with relevant socio-cultural language suited to the immediate environment (Komarek, 2003).

Hence, it is counterintuitive that the reality to deal with in Africa is the linguistic dominance of the English language and other colonial languages in all corners and levels of interaction, education, politics, governance, and corporate. As a matter of concern, the existence of this in almost every country of sub-Saharan Africa is gradually subverting the acquisition, learning and use of African languages (Adeyemi, 2008; Bamgbose, 1999). In the case of Nigeria, there are concerns around language shift gradually leading to language loss if proactive steps are not taken to correct this (Mustapha, 2014).

3 Theoretical Framework

Pierre Bourdieu and Jean-Claude Passeron's work, *La reproduction*, a French word acceptably translated to "Reproduction," provided the theoretical underpinning, which has guided research on cultural reproduction in subsequent years. Here, the subjectivism and symbolic force concealed in the pedagogic action of the Western education on the previous colony were put in a broader perspective. This pedagogic action, that is, education in the broadest form, was portrayed to be more encompassing and reflective of the imposition syndrome of cultural arbitrariness by the dominant group and class (Bourdieu and Passeron, 1990, p 14).

Perhaps, the important concept that is relatable in this context is the role that the reproduction of culture—through the educational system—plays in the formation of social structures. This reproduction sought to propose a model of social mediation in the school system (teachers, students and their parents) with objective truth. Meanwhile, in reality, what it does is transmit cultural capital across generations—often, against their will—as well as stamp distinctions with credentials. In the analysis of the pros and cons of the symbolic efficacy of educational titles, Bourdieu assessed it as a true social essence, a public attestation of 'gifts' or individual 'merit', aside from the guarantee of technical competencies (Bourdieu and Passeron, 1990).

In addition to this, Bourdieu (1974) also touched on the social selection that exist at the different levels of the educational system as well as the established difference in linguistic codes, often expressed as 'linguistic and cultural capital'. In this simulation, cultural capital is said to exist in three forms: a disposition of the mind and body, the objectification as cultural goods, and the institutionalisation as educational qualifications. However, in practice, social and cultural exclusion is practised, which is a subversion by a socially and culturally dominated class (Nash, 1990; Bourdieu, 1974). Bourdieu argues that such

practices can be recognised and that those who inherit the dominant culture do actively strive to maintain what they regard as their symbolic patrimony, their heritage, by various systematic devices. (Nash, 1990, p 440).

In another view, the sociocultural theory assumes that learning and interpersonal interactions are inseparable in cultural frameworks (Kapoor and Shizha, 2010; Bourdieu, 1977). Acknowledging this, Chinn (2007) further concretised a socially situated learning as that which integrates the recognition of values, emotions, experiences, and cultural contexts to learning. For Bourdieu, “the culture is the language, the categories and the principles of living, implying that culture is all encompassing and seeks to draw the parallel of structural homology across its various elements-its rules or codes of housing, eating, gift exchange, etc. (Nash, 1990, p 445).

This is the understanding that Bernstein (2003, p 20) also had in his scholastic adventure when drawing the nexus between sociolinguistic and educational codes. The thesis examined two strands of relationship: one delineates how class regulates the structure of communication within the family, which then translates to the initial sociolinguistic coding orientation of the children; secondly, the thesis elucidates how class regulates the institutionalising of elaborated codes in education, the forms of their transmission and then the realisation.

These ideological perspectives are based on socialisation within the family and the seemingly progressive pedagogies within the educational system. According to Bernstein (2003), the informal everyday experience and communication within the family and various social groups create procedures and performances that are elementary to formal education. An experience which, without debate, subsumes de-contextualising and re-contextualising. It is then problematic that this process of recontextualising and decontextualising abstracts from these informal experiences (pg. 28). This describes the polemics of western approaches to knowledge, subtly decontextualising indigenous knowledge

production and dissemination (Kapoor and Shizha, 2010).

4 State of the Art: A reflection on Western Education and Indigenous Epistemology in Southwest Nigeria.

The south-western region is one of the six geo-political zones in Nigeria and unique for its characteristic—economic hub, commercial capital, and moribund educational institution in the country. It has one of the largest and busiest seaports on the continent of Africa. The crux of governance in Nigeria was in the city of Lagos since the amalgamation in 1914 to 1991 when the federal capital was moved to Abuja. Southwest Nigeria, which comprises 6 states (Oyo, Ogun, Lagos, Osun, Ekiti, and Ondo), is the cradle of the Yoruba ethnic group- one of the major cultural groups in the country (Lagos, n.d.). The Yoruba cultural landscape extends northward into the country and other parts of Nigeria and in some African countries, notably, the eastern region of the Republic of Benin (the revered Dahomey region in historical accounts), Northern Ghana and Togo. Also, the Yoruba cultural landscape extends outside of Africa to Brazil, the Caribbean, and the West Indian Islands (Fadamiro and Adedeji, 2016; Aderemi, 2009).

Presently, the region is the most diverse geopolitical zone in the country in terms of its huge multicultural, multi-ethnic presence, which is owed to the concentration of commercial and economic activities. According to the Commission (2006), 39.8 million out of 46 million people living in southwestern Nigeria as of 2006 were Yoruba. However, population statistics released by the Federal Office of Statistics in 2019 showed that the Yoruba population must have risen to about 40.9 million (Fadamiro and Adedeji, 2016).

Notably, the root of formal education in Nigeria can be traced to this region. Out of the first five universities in Nigeria, three were founded in the southwest: the premier university, which is the University of Ibadan in Oyo State, was founded in the year 1948; Obafemi

Awolowo University in Osun State, founded in 1961, is the third, and the University of Lagos in Lagos State founded in 1962 is the fifth in that order. Not only that, the present southwest is home to 54 universities out of all the 174 universities in the entire 6 geopolitical zones in the country. By implication, it means almost one-third of all the universities in the country are in the southwest (Mogaji, 2019).

Beyond the numbers, we could infer the region's early exposure to formal education. Coupled with the concentration of economic activities, makes it attractive to people from different cultural backgrounds to reside in the region. As a result, the mixed social ecosystem encouraged the adoption of English as a medium of communication at the different levels of interaction. This alone is a prime example of why the use of indigenous language (Yoruba) is limited in the region, compared to other regions of the country where indigenous language still records a substantial degree of usage at all levels—from the grassroots to daily interactions as well as business and corporate communication. To the growing elite and learned community, the English language is fanciful and fashionable and an important marker of status, thereby raising a generation that lacks the foundational knowledge about their cultural identity and origin.

This is not an attempt to underscore the importance and impact of formal education, in this context, foreign education, but the impact on indigenous knowledge is a critical question to sociocultural reproduction and sustainability. The awareness of the importance of education has led to a deliberate quest of parents striving to give the best of this education to their ward since it translates to better jobs, a higher standard of living and status. This increased enlightenment is consequential to equal education opportunity for both genders. Previously, females were relegated to home chores, but as knowledge evolved, they also had the same right to education. In fact, professional and economically independent women are clustered in all the corridors of southwest Nigeria (Shakya, 2010; Shakya, 2008). This is further corroborated by the level of literacy index in southwest Nigeria—the highest in the country. As of 2018, 89 percent of males and 80.6 percent of females were

literate (Varrella, 2020; Norberg-Hodge, 1992).

Economically, the predominantly agrarian region has now shifted to a more capitalist economy. The sociocultural environment is rapidly absorbing the modern development agenda, where all people care about is pursuing degrees, getting a job and earning money, while pursuing indigenous knowledge, social engagement and participation are given lesser priority (Barua, 2007). The family that should be a critical player in advancing indigenous pedagogies as we have seen above are now preoccupied with employment, leaving the gap unfilled, especially in this dispensation where more and more families adopt nucleated living to the communal style of living that was synonymous with this ethnic group in previous years. This calculable dissociation of present-day generation from their extended family-hood can be explained in a scenario where children only know their learned uncles and aunties and, by extension, their grandparents due to non-participation and screened social engagements (Kawano, 2011).

Moreover, education in Nigeria is similar to Shakya (2010, p 136) analysis of Nepal's education. In southwest Nigeria, similar to other parts of the country, the education system is based on the (1)-6-3-3-4 formula: a year for pre-primary education, then six years of primary or elementary, three years junior secondary education, three years senior secondary education, and a minimum of four years tertiary education (Ekundayo, 2019). The ladder goes on to acquiring master's and PhD degrees, and the higher the formal education acquired, the less contact with the sociocultural and indigenous ecosystem. The impact is a gradual erosion of values, social construct and cultural knowledge—a common occurrence in the societal frame of southwest Nigeria now.

Contributing to this discourse, Gbeminiyi Laolu-Adewale, a Harvard graduate, in a random debate online on the recurring trend of international education of elite children and political officeholders, argued that local education should be given to kids up to 17 years of age, “simply because children must be well grounded in their culture and particularly

for us as Africans, we owe it to our kids to give them not just book education but street education in their early years (Laolu-Adewale, 2021). Here, street education is a symbolism of sociocultural learning, which formal education has completely ignored or overgeneralised and particularly cannot offer. This is because, situated in this social learning quadrant, are imbibed values of a culture, emotions, experiences, cultural learning, and a reliable understanding of the indigenous environment (Chinn, 2007). More reason Bourdieu (1977)'s sociocultural theory propounded that learning cannot be dissociated from the interpersonal interactions entrenched in cultural framework (Kapoor and Shizha, 2010).

Apart from the fact that Western methodologies and approaches to knowledge decontextualise knowledge production and dissemination, the disposition of the learned class or academics to cultural knowledge and diversity is void of the needed recognition. However, integrating cultural diffusion into an established educational framework could enable an alternative style of knowledge production and assimilation in society. More importantly, this could enhance fluidity in the accumulation of applicable knowledge

5 Decolonising Education: A panacea to Sociocultural Reproduction

Smith (1999), one of the renowned advocates of decolonising education, in his scholastic work, conceived decolonisation as a social and political process of undoing the myriad impacts of the colonial project. And then, realigning indigenous experience in line with the historical (traditional values, philosophies, and knowledge) as well as contemporary discourse, in a line-upon-line precept of reclaiming and recreating alternative indigenous histories and epistemologies. This was rightly framed by Kempf (2011, p 86) who obliged that, "African history is knowable, and this knowledge does not rely on Eurocentric understanding and conceptions of civilisation".

The second procedure, as proposed by Smith (1999), is the development of indigenous projects that can facilitate multifarious processes of self-determination. In his defence, the methodology of undoing these colonial impacts embellished in curricula and underlying theories of knowledge, has to be prompt including stories and long suppressed knowledge should be grafted into the curricula and revaluing indigenous knowledge should be given premium at the grassroots, that is, indigenous communities and venerated in the formal education ecosystem (Kapoor and Shizha, 2010). In the quest for using education as an instrument for addressing issues pertaining to human rights, self-reliance and social justice in both developed and developing countries, the theme of development education emerged in the 1970s. According to Elliott *et al.*, (2010), development education emerged in response to the growth of development organisations and the decolonisation process.

Profoundly, two broader perspectives were recorded to have impacted the concept of development education in the 1980s, this includes Freire (1972) advocacy for participatory learning and the globalist approach of the World Studies Project led by Robin Richardson and later by Simon Fisher and Dave Hicks ¹. However, Freire (1972) emphasis on participatory learning, and the relationship between education and social change is the first time the subject of education-social relationship emerged in the discourse of development education. Fast forward to 2007, a more robust definition was given to the development education practice in the Development Education Exchange in Europe Project as, “an active learning process, founded on values of solidarity, equality, induction and cooperation which then enables the transition from basic awareness if international development priorities to personal development and informed action through the understanding of the cause and effects of global issues” (Elliott *et al.*, 2010, p 227).

¹see Hicks, D. (1990). World studies 8–13: a short history, 1980–89. Westminster Studies in Education, 13, 61–80.

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According to Bourn (2008), the triangular pivots of development education simulate cultural understanding and commitment to citizenship and sustainable development within the English education system. Based on the thrust upon which development education is framed, the only “valid knowledge” syndrome of Western education should be adjudged antithetical in the understanding of knowledge. Going forward, knowledge, especially as far as Sub-Saharan Africa is concerned, should be institutionalised based on the syndicate of Western education frameworks and sociocultural perspectives. Anything other than this will contravene the development education and decolonisation agenda.

6 Conclusion

In light of the gradual disappearance of indigenous knowledge and language usage, particularly among the Yorubas of southwestern Nigeria, this critical review is an awakening to the implications for sociocultural sustainability and reproduction in the region. To preserve historical traditions, values and sociocultural ethos at the grassroots, there should be deliberate revaluing of language use and the veneration of sociocultural engagements and knowledge. Similarly, educational institutions should be a platform for the unfolding and regeneration of knowledge without excluding indigenous or local epistemology. For quite a long while, the litanies of western dominance in the education system and the systemic commodification of indigenous knowledge within the academic corridor has a far-reaching effect on sociocultural reproduction, especially in the face of the current upsurge of globalisation. In forming policy decisions in education, the curriculum should be reviewed to integrate indigenous perspectives and western perspective in reconstituting holistic knowledge that is culturally inclusive and socially relevant.

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